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finesse, a silky mouthfeel, and a lingering effervescence that elevates each sip. A glass of Dom Pérignon, for instance, should offer a complex bouquet—think almond, hazelnut, and freshly baked brioche. The longer the Champagne ages, the more developed and nuanced these aromas become.

THE POPULAR BRANDS

For decades, Cristal was the go-to Champagne for the ultra-wealthy, a symbol of indulgence and luxury produced by the house of Louis Roederer. Said to be crafted from the finest grapes grown in their Grand Cru vineyards, Cristal was positioned as the pinnacle of Champagne. The story goes that it was first made in 1876 for a Russian Czar who demanded a clear, flat-bottomed bottle to ensure it hadn't been tampered with or used to conceal explosives. But Cristal's creamy texture, complex layers of flavour, and high acidity soon extended its appeal beyond aristocrats, catching the eye and palate of some unlikely admirers.

Jay-Z, the American rapper, is often credited with catapulting Cristal into mainstream pop culture. In his lyrics, Cristal became the symbol of ultimate success: "Give me that sweet stuff, give me that Cristal" and bottles flowed freely in his music videos. Suddenly, Cristal wasn't just a drink for the elite; it became a badge of success for anyone who had made it big. But Roederer didn't appreciate its Champagne being associated with rap culture and the debauched world of nightclubs. And when Frédéric Rouzaud, its CEO, expressed

public discomfort in an interview, a bitter fallout ensued with Jay-Z.

Jay-Z swore off Cristal and called for its boycott. And soon found a new Champagne to champion: Armand de Brignac, a relatively unknown and unremarkable wine from the mid-tier house of Cattier. He adopted and rebranded it as "Ace of Spades" with a flashy gold bottle. Almost overnight, Armand de Brignac became the Champagne of choice for the hip-hop industry. And despite lacking pedigree, it began commanding prices that rivalled Cristal, proving that in the world of luxury, perception and marketing can often matter more than tradition and quality.

Moët & Chandon is perhaps the world's most successfully marketed Champagne brand. It sells over 30 million bottles of its non-vintage Brut each year, mainly using grapes purchased from external vineyards. Its popularity is fuelled by its association with glamour and celebrities; it's the official Champagne of the Oscars and has had ambassadors like Roger Federer and Scarlett Johansson. Yet, true connois-